

GRACE

ANDY SNOKE

"For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, lest anyone should boast" (Ephesians 2:9).

"Grace" is defined by the Merriam Webster Dictionary as:

- a: unmerited divine assistance given to humans for their regeneration or sanctification
- b: a virtue coming from God
- c: a state of sanctification enjoyed through divine assistance.

Grace is simply stated as "unmerited favor." In other words, it is a "divine" approval and favor completely unrelated to what we deserve. We don't merit or deserve God's favor. It is given as a free gift.

Grace is what happens when a boy or girl, a man or woman comes to the cross. Favor. Blessing. Forgiveness. All of these blessings are bestowed in a moment's time when a repentant heart comes to Jesus.

The Thief On The Cross

The "thief on the cross" who was crucified beside the cross of

Christ, received that Grace in a moment of time. Without the ability to fully describe his needs, he simply acknowledged that this Jesus was God. He acknowledged his sins internally. Grace visited him in the Person of Jesus Christ and a door was opened to heaven.

"One of the criminals who were hanged there was hurling abuse at Him, saying, 'Are You not the Christ? Save Yourself and us!' But the other answered, and rebuking him said, 'Do you not even fear God, since you are under the same sentence of condemnation? And we indeed are suffering justly, for we are receiving what we deserve for our deeds; but this man has done nothing wrong.' And he was saying, 'Jesus, remember me when You come in Your kingdom!' And He said to him, 'Truly I say to you, today you shall be with Me in Paradise.'" (Luke 23:39-43, NASB).

I love this simple passage! The thief could not recite the traditional sinner's prayer. He was most likely so broken and humbled by his sin that he dared not to even ask for forgiveness in his mind. He simply asked, "The Christ" (the anointed) to remember him when He came into His kingdom. Jesus had plans for the thief far beyond what the thief could have imagined.

"Today you will be with Me in Paradise," Jesus said. Grace came as a Person to the thief.

It is hard for us to imagine, that every moral failure, every sin, every mistake, every regret can be erased and washed away, forgiven by His grace. A "second chance" at life comes in the Person of grace. Sometimes, we find "Grace", and at times, "Grace finds us".

The Woman At The Well

"Grace" in the form of Jesus Christ came to the woman at the well. Jesus purposely passed through Samaria for this display of Divine Grace. The Jews despised the Samaritans. Often the Jews would travel up to 100 miles just to avoid stepping on the soil of the Samaritans. But on this day Grace purposely came and sought out one that was culturally the lowest of the low.

According to Jewish custom, a husband could talk to his wife in public, but not to other women. A Jew would avoid at all costs speaking to the despised Samaritans. Here in this story, Jesus comes to a Samaritan woman who had "five husbands" and was at that time living with another man. As our local elder Brandon Snoke mentioned in his message at our local service, Jesus did not incrementally reach down with His grace for those who seemed to be most deserving. He went directly to those who needed it the most. Grace came to the woman at the well.

"Jesus answered her, 'If you knew the gift of God, and who it is that is saying to you, 'Give me a drink,' you would have asked him, and he would have given you living water.' The woman said to him, 'Sir, you have nothing to draw water with, and the well is deep. Where do you get that living water? Are you greater than our father Jacob? He gave us the well and drank from it himself, as did his sons and his livestock.' Jesus said to her, 'Everyone who drinks of this water will be thirsty again, but whoever drinks of the water that I will give him will never be thirsty again. The water that I will give him will become in him a spring of water welling up to eternal life.' The woman said to him, 'Sir, give me this water so that I will not be thirsty or have to come here to draw water'"

"Jesus said to her, 'Go, call your husband, and come here.' The woman answered him, 'I have no husband.' Jesus said to her, 'You are right in saying, 'I have no husband'; for you have had five husbands, and the one you now have is not your husband. What you have said is true.' The woman said to him, 'Sir, I perceive that you are a prophet. Our fathers worshiped on this mountain, but you say that in Jerusalem is the place where people ought to worship.' Jesus said to her, 'Woman, believe me, the hour is coming when neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem will you worship the Father. You worship what you do not know; we worship what we know, for salvation is from the Jews. But the hour is coming, and is now here when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, for the Father is seeking such people to worship him. God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.' The woman said to him, 'I know that Messiah is coming (he who is called Christ). When he comes, he will tell us all things.' Jesus said to her, 'I who speak to you am he.' (John 4:10-26, ESV).

The Good Samaritan

Jesus gave another example of how we as Christians should

demonstrate grace, unmerited favor to humanity. Once again, he describes this parable using the lowly (despised at that time) name of "Samaritan."

A certain man fell among thieves. He was beaten, robbed, and left half dead. A priest passed by the half-dead stranger and only looks upon him, with no act of compassion. A Levite soon passed the same way and also ignored the plight of this stranger. You looked straight ahead. They had other things more important than to show "grace" to a stranger.

Soon, a Samaritan passed by. The Samaritan offered what the priest and the Levite should have offered but refused to: grace, love, compassion.

"And behold, a certain lawyer stood up and tested Him, saying, 'Teacher, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?'"

He said to him, 'What is written in the law? What is your reading of it?'"

So he answered and said, "'You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul, with all your strength, and with all your mind, and 'your neighbor as yourself.'"

And He said to him, "You have answered rightly; do this and you will live."

But he, wanting to justify himself, said to Jesus, "And who is my neighbor?"

Then Jesus answered and said: "A certain man went down from Jerusalem to Jericho, and fell among thieves, who stripped him of his clothing, wounded him, and departed, leaving him half dead. Now by chance a certain priest came down that road. And when he saw him, he passed by on the other side. Likewise a Levite, when he arrived at the place, came and looked, and passed by on the other side. But a certain Samaritan, as he journeyed, came where he was. And when he saw him, he had compassion. So he went to him and bandaged his wounds, pouring on oil and wine; and he set him on his own animal, brought him to an inn, and took care of him. On the next day, when he departed, he took out two denarii, gave them to the innkeeper, and said to him, 'Take care of him; and whatever more you spend, when I come again, I will repay you.' So which of these three do you think was neighbor to him who fell among the thieves?"

And he said, "He who showed mercy on him."

Then Jesus said to him, "Go and do likewise" (Luke 10:25-37, NKJV).

What I find such an interesting side note is the implication today of the word "Samaritan." In Jesus' day, it was not a good word to use. There was great jealousy, resistance, and tensions between the Jews and the Samaritans. If a Jew used the word "Samaritan," it most frequently was in a derogatory manner.

Now, think of the hour that we live in today. When you hear the word "Samaritan" it is almost always associated with mercy, kindness, compassion, and grace, e.g. The Good Samaritan Hospital, The Samaritan's Purse (Franklin Graham), and many more examples.

This is the result of the application of “Grace”.

John Newton

After a long and arduous conversion, John Newton finally found “Grace.” John Newton had made his living as a slave trader, dealing in the merchandise of misery. After much trial, John forsook his godless trade in exchange for Grace.

I am sure that John Newton had many nightmares of the lives he helped destroy as a result of his past life. There was much to keep him awake at night. But God’s unmerited, undeserved favor finally came to John Newton. John Newton forsook his despicable trade, and followed Christ for his remaining years with His life.

In 1779 John Newton published the very familiar song “Amazing Grace.”

Amazing grace! How sweet the sound
That saved a wretch like me!
I once was lost, but now am found;
Was blind, but now I see.

‘Twas grace that taught my heart to fear,
And grace my fears relieved;
How precious did that grace appear
The hour I first believed.

Through many dangers, toils and snares,
I have already come;
‘Tis grace hath brought me safe thus far,
And grace will lead me home.

The Lord has promised good to me,
His word my hope secures;
He will my shield and portion be,
As long as life endures.

Yea, when this flesh and heart shall fail,
And mortal life shall cease,
I shall possess, within the veil,
A life of joy and peace.

The world shall soon dissolve like snow,
The sun refuse to shine;
But God, who called me here below,
Shall be forever mine.

When we’ve been there ten thousand years,
Bright shining as the sun,
We’ve no less days to sing God’s praise
Than when we’d first begun.

The Apostle Paul

Grace found Saul of Tarsus on the road to Damascus. Saul, the religious, legalistic, pious Pharisee (Acts 26:5) was on a mission to hunt down men and women of “The Way” and bring them bound in chains to Jerusalem. The Bible says that he was “still breathing threats and murder among the disciples” the day that Grace found Paul.

In a moment, in the “twinkling of the eye,” in the blinding light of Truth, in the revelation and appearance of Grace itself, Jesus Christ, Saul found his life-transforming Grace.

One moment Saul is sitting proudly high above all others, piously hunting down the followers of Jesus. The next moment he is on the ground; blind and soul-searching for real truth, as Truth Himself stood before him. What took John Newton many years to accept, Saul experienced in a blinding moment of time.

“Who are you, Lord?” Saul exclaims. It is almost as if Saul (his named soon will be changed to Paul) is saying, “I thought I knew who you were. But who, really are you?”

“But Saul, still breathing threats and murder against the disciples of the Lord, went to the high priest and asked him for letters to the synagogues at Damascus, so that if he found any belonging to the Way, men or women, he might bring them bound to Jerusalem. Now as he went on his way, he approached Damascus, and suddenly a light from heaven shone around him. And falling to the ground, he heard a voice saying to him, “Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?” And he said, “Who are you, Lord?” And he said, “I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting. But rise and enter the city, and you will be told what you are to do.” The men who were traveling with him stood speechless, hearing the voice but seeing no one. Saul rose from the ground, and although his eyes were opened, he saw nothing. So they led him by the hand and brought him into Damascus. And for three days he was without sight, and neither ate nor drank.

Now there was a disciple at Damascus named Ananias. The Lord said to him in a vision, “Ananias.” And he said, “Here I am, Lord.” And the Lord said to him, “Rise and go to the street called Straight, and at the house of Judas look for a man of Tarsus named Saul, for behold, he is praying, and he has seen in a vision a man named Ananias come in and lay his hands on him so that he might regain his sight.” But Ananias answered, “Lord, I have heard from many about this man, how much evil he has done to your saints at Jerusalem. And here he has authority from the chief priests to bind all who call on your name.” But the Lord said to him, “Go, for he is a chosen instrument of mine to carry my name before the Gentiles and kings and the children of Israel. For I will show him how much he must suffer for the sake of my name” (Acts 9:1-16, ESV).

Like John Newton, Paul had many occasions to be depressed over his memories of his past life. Men and women had lost their lives as the results of the missions of Saul. Yet Paul listed a simple formula for overcoming the past:

“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus” (Philippians 3:13-14, NKJV).

It is no wonder that Paul uses the word “grace” more than any other New Testament writer as a result of his experience with Jesus.

Bible Study Tools online quotes the following interesting statement: It is worth noting that, though Jesus is never quoted as using the word “grace,” His teaching is full of the unmerited favor of God. Perhaps the parable of the prodigal son is the most obvious example. In that parable, grace is extended to one who has no basis upon which to be shown that grace, other than the

fact that he has asked in humility and repentance to be shown it. Other parables demonstrate grace in the teaching of Jesus, perhaps most notably the parable of the laborers in the vineyard (Matthew 20:1-16) and the parable of the great supper (Luke 14:16-24).

How can we describe with human words the magnitude of what grace really is? It is a Person. It is Jesus. It is clean. It is life changing. It is eternal. It is His favor. It is free. It is unmerited. It is available to all who ask.

How do we reconcile our “works of faith” with the unmerited grace and favor of God? I love how Dr. Ryrie so simply explains this concept in his notes. I will first quote the scripture and then provide Dr. Ryrie’s annotations:

“For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, lest anyone should boast. For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand that we should walk in them” (Ephesians 2:8-9, NKJV).

Dr. Ryrie explains this passage as follows:

1. Salvation is “by grace through faith.”
2. Faith involves acknowledgment of the gospel (Romans 10:14).
3. Faith involves acknowledgment of the truth of its message.
4. Personal reception of the Saviour (John 1:12).
5. Works cannot save (Ephesians 2:9).
6. But good works always accompany salvation (James 2:17).

How To Be Saved

How do we receive Salvation? Though there is no special or set “formulae”, what are the scriptures that can guide a child or an adult to Christ? What are the simple steps that we could commit to memory to help lead others to Christ?

There are many Bible tracts that easily provide the basic scriptures for accepting Christ, but in closing, I will list the popular “Romans Road to Salvation” (This particular text is taken from Teen Missions).

1. We are all sinners by nature and by choice. *“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God”* (Romans 3:23, NKJV).
2. We receive eternal life as a free gift. *“For the wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord”* (Romans 6:23, NKJV).
3. God demonstrated His love for us, His enemies. *“But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us”* (Romans 5:8, NKJV).
4. We must trust and surrender to Jesus, *“that if you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus and believe in your heart that God has raised Him from the dead, you will be saved. For with the heart one believes unto righteousness, and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation”* (Romans 10:9-10, NKJV).
5. Our assurance of salvation is through Jesus. *“For whoever calls on the name of the Lord shall be saved”* (Romans 10:13, NKJV).

If you are in need of “Grace in your life,” don’t waste another moment. Jesus is very near. You can embrace His forgiveness, love, and grace for your life right now.

“Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ” (Ephesians 1:2, ESV).✝

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Headquarters:
802 Airport Road
North Battleford, SK S9A 2Z3 Canada

Mailing Address:
P.O. Box 934
North Battleford, SK S9A 2Z3 Canada

Telephone:
(306) 445-2733

Email:
info@globalmissionsinc.org

Online:
www.globalmissionsinc.org

Traveling Ministry Contact List:
www.globalmissionsinc.org/about

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